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Nov/Dec 2026



"Shoots & Ladders"
John Gress



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THE PHOTOGRAPHER

Official Publication of the Texas Professional Photographers Association, Inc.

VOLUME 61 - #6 Nov/Dec 2026



"Shoots & Ladders" was created by John Gress in his Chicago studio using a pair of vintage Mole Richardson movie lights as part of the set. John used a large strip softbox from camera left to create the illumination that appears to be coming from that fixture. "Because I wanted to preserve detail in the lenses of the Mole Richardson lights, I photographed the scene at 1/200, f/11 and ISO 100 and built the rest of the lighting around that exposure," he explains. The main light was a 28-inch Mola Setti, positioned in front of an octabox, with both lights metered to f/8. Together, they created a circular area of illumination with a gradual transition toward the edges. He also used a gridded strip softbox as a hair light. "The ladder and vintage movie lights gave us a lot to work with compositionally, and I liked the contrast between the industrial equipment and the model's wardrobe and pose." John will be teaching a class on "Harnessing Flash" at the 2027 Texas School of Professional Photography.



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5 The Final Frame: With Gratitude
A Message from TPPA President Cornell T. McGhee

6 Mastering Composites
Shooting, Organizing, and Retouching by Michelle VanTine

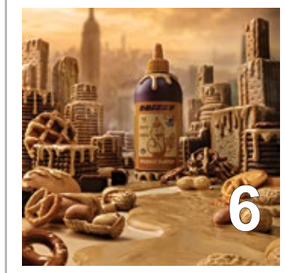
14 Chasing the Story
Authentic Moments in the American West by Amy Peterson

20 The Art of Seeing
Guide to Creative Freedom by Leslie Hoyt

27 TPPA Loses Past President
The Passing of Ed Alexander by Bill Hedrick

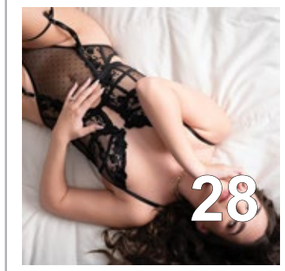
28 Cinematic Motivated Lighting
For Boudoir Photography by Lori Poole

32 Beyond the Little Mermaid
The Making of "Poor Unfortunate Souls" by Brad Barton









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From the President

Cornell T. McGhee, TPPA President



The Final Frame: With Gratitude for the Journey

A Farewell Message from the President

Every meaningful photograph begins with a decision to notice – to pause, to look closely, and to preserve something that might otherwise pass unseen. As I prepare to step away from my role as President, I find myself doing the same: pausing to take in the remarkable people, experiences, and shared purpose that have defined this chapter.

It has been a privilege to serve a community that understands both the craft and the responsibility of photography. Our members do more than make images. They document lives, preserve history, and help people see the world with greater clarity. The talent in our Association is impressive; your generosity towards one another is even more so.

Together, we have welcomed new voices, strengthened professional standards, and created opportunities for learning and connection. None of that work belongs to one person. It reflects the commitment of our board, staff, volunteers, partners, educators, and members – people who consistently bring ideas, energy, and care to this association.

Photography will continue to evolve, as it always has. New tools will emerge, expectations will shift, and the ways we create and share images will keep expanding. Yet the heart of the profession will remain familiar: vision, discipline, trust, and the human connection between photographer and subject. I am confident this association will meet the future with curiosity and courage while holding fast to those values.

Thank you for every conversation, every candid question, every shared success, and every moment of encouragement. Thank you for trusting me to help steward an organization that matters deeply to so many. I leave this role with immense respect for the work you do and lasting gratitude for the welcome you extended to me.

Although this is a farewell, it is not an ending. As I transition into the role of Chairman of the Board, I will continue to serve the needs of our Association. I look forward to seeing you at Imaging USA, WPPI, and the Texas School of Professional Photography. Stop me in the hallway and share your thoughts!

With gratitude,

Cornell T. McGhee, M.Photog., Cr ., Ed.D
TPPA President

If you are not a member of Texas PPA, this is my personal invitation to you to join!
Email Steve Kozak, TPPA Executive Director, at *Steve@tppa.org* or call 972-601-9070.



MASTERING COMPOSITES

Shooting, Organizing, and Retouching

by
Michelle VanTine
Texas School Instructor

I have a dry erase board on my fridge for weekly quotes. Sometimes the quotes are silly – just there to make me smile as I stumble half-awake with my coffee and a messy bun, trying to motivate myself for my day. Some are more serious, reminding me that growth rarely happens inside the boundaries of what already feels comfortable. As an artist, I have always tried to find the edges of what I know how to do – and then lean over them.

There is a kind of creative auto-pilot that can happen in photography. We wake up, make the same pictures, reach for the same lenses, and light things the same way. There is nothing wrong with mastery or consistency, but it can sometimes cause us to feel that our career has become somewhat of a Groundhog Day. Maybe the antidote is simply being willing to do something that scares you a little.

That opportunity came when Miami's biggest food stylist reached out to me with a creative concept that seemed wildly ambitious. Standing in the kitchen, I glanced at my fridge and shook my head with a smile of disbelief, "Develop the habit of biting off more than you can chew… and chewing." I took a deep breath, "Let's do it," I responded. Here are the behind the scenes of a seven-hour image build, and the ensuing 27-image composite with AI designed background. I'll also share my most useful tips and tricks for suspiciously perfect composites. Let's chew!

How do you actually pull off a composite like this? It starts with the set. Here's how I lit and shot it, and a few things you'll want to keep in mind when building your own composites.

I used two Godox AD 600 Pro II strobes. The main light had a three-foot double diffusion soft box and the other one to the right was bare bulb, bouncing off the ceiling. I used a large black matboard to block the spill light on the right.

Shot Setup – Since a seriously ambitious composite was on the horizon, I had to make sure I captured all the images precisely for my next step in Photoshop. When working on a composite, here are my top four tips to set yourself up for success.



1. Shoot With a Tripod – Mark its location on the ground, and tighten every knob. Make sure there is space around it so that anyone walking by won't bump it.

2. Shoot in Manual and Lock In Your Settings – Lock your exposure, white balance, focus, and focal length. Once everything is dialed in, don't let the camera make decisions for you. Consistency between frames is everything when you're building a composite.

3. Tether – I use Capture One but there are other options. I turn on Live View so that anyone working on the composition can see how it's reading on camera. Once it looks good, I point to the section I'm capturing and take a picture. Then, I take the shot and mark it in Capture One. This allows me to filter out which ones were the winning shots without having to sort through the whole gallery.

4. Get "In Case" Shots – I always take a lot of "in case shots" of everything: the background before I start, the product individually, extras of this or that... especially when I'm going to do something irreversible like splashing or drizzling. Sometimes you find yourself knee-deep in a composite and you need a clean label or an untouched background to reinsert into your image and those shots become lifesavers.



Principles of Art – These are principles of art which we kept in mind as we built our city.

- **Perspective:** Leading lines which directed the eye to the product.
- **Depth:** Foreground, middleground, background.
- **Balance:** We wanted to stack a wide array of "peanut-butter-worthy" snacks, but it had the potential to get very busy very quickly. We constantly tried to balance variety with cohesion. We had originally planned on using apples, but their green skin ended up drawing too much visual weight. Keeping the scene monochromatic was a shift we made to avoid visual overload.

The Photoshop Composite – The finished image ended up being a 27-image composite. Each stack was photographed when the stylist created the perfect drizzle. After the shot, the peanut butter continued to drip past the point of perfection which is why I had to photograph the city stack by stack. I marked each winning frame as we went and exported them to a separate folder at the end.

For the composite, I began with the base layer, the build without the peanut butter, and composited the drizzles one stack at a time. The trick to making all those layers feel like they actually belonged together? Good selections. We'll get into that next.

After a laborious composite, it was time for the AI-powered background. I typically use Nano Banana 3.1 for backgrounds. It does the best at backgrounds. I've found that Firefly does well at fixing small local adjustments, and Nano Banana does better at large global designs.

Tips for AI Prompting – AI prompting has practically become its own art, and Photoshop's Generative Fill has a very specific "dialect." Here is a summary of the best Dos and Don'ts to get the most realistic and accurate results out of Photoshop's Generative Fill. Here are some hints for effective phrasing:

- **Focus on Nouns and Adjectives** – Describe exactly what you want in the selected area, not on what you want it to "do." Do not use command words like "add," "create," "change," "make," "fix," or "place."

The AI is designed to interpret descriptions of a final state, not instructions on how to get there. For example, don't circle a pair of sneakers and write "replace the sneakers with …." Circle the sneakers, skip the verb and write what you want there, "Light brown, weathered leather hiking boots, with a small amount of dirt on them."

- **Specify Lighting and Perspective** – Include terms that describe the environment's global lighting, directional light, and any other relevant environmental information. For example, "Light brown, weathered leather hiking boots, with a small amount of dirt on them. Soft warm diffused light coming from the back left."

- **Use Style Keywords** – Include the medium or style in your prompt. Examples of this are "cinematic, nostalgic, gritty, natural," etc.

- **Avoid Negative Prompts** – AI can sometimes struggle with negative phrasing. If you type "no sunglasses," for example, the model may still focus on the word "sunglasses" and generate them. When possible, describe the positive version of what you want to see in the selected area rather than telling the AI what you don't want.

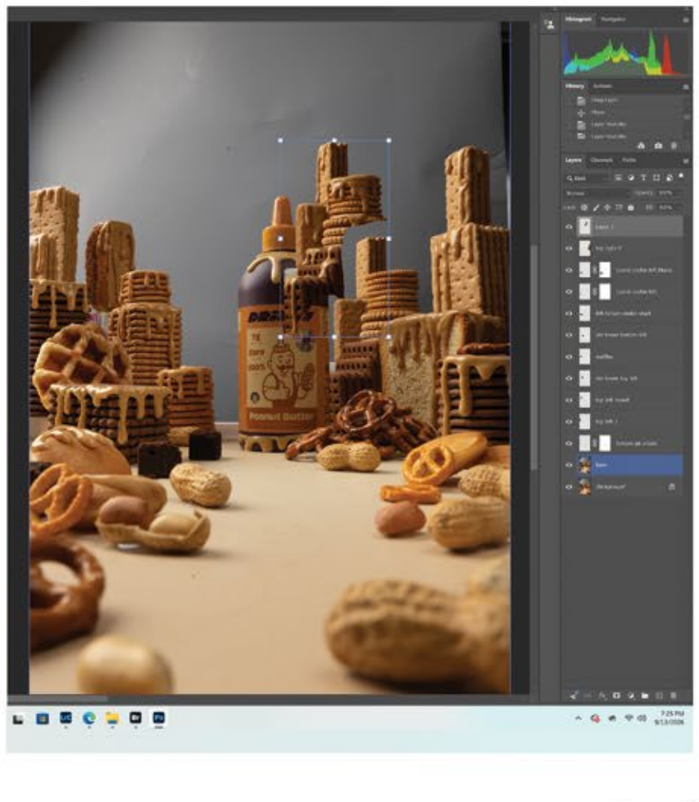
Integrating AI Elements – When AI elements are dropped into a scene, it can quickly become obvious that they came from a different source. If you've ever tried Photoshop's "Harmonize" feature, you know why I'm laughing and not spending any time on that particular tool. It's important to go in and rework the inserted element. Work on the shadows and highlights, adjust the color balance, add gradients or masks… make it fit.

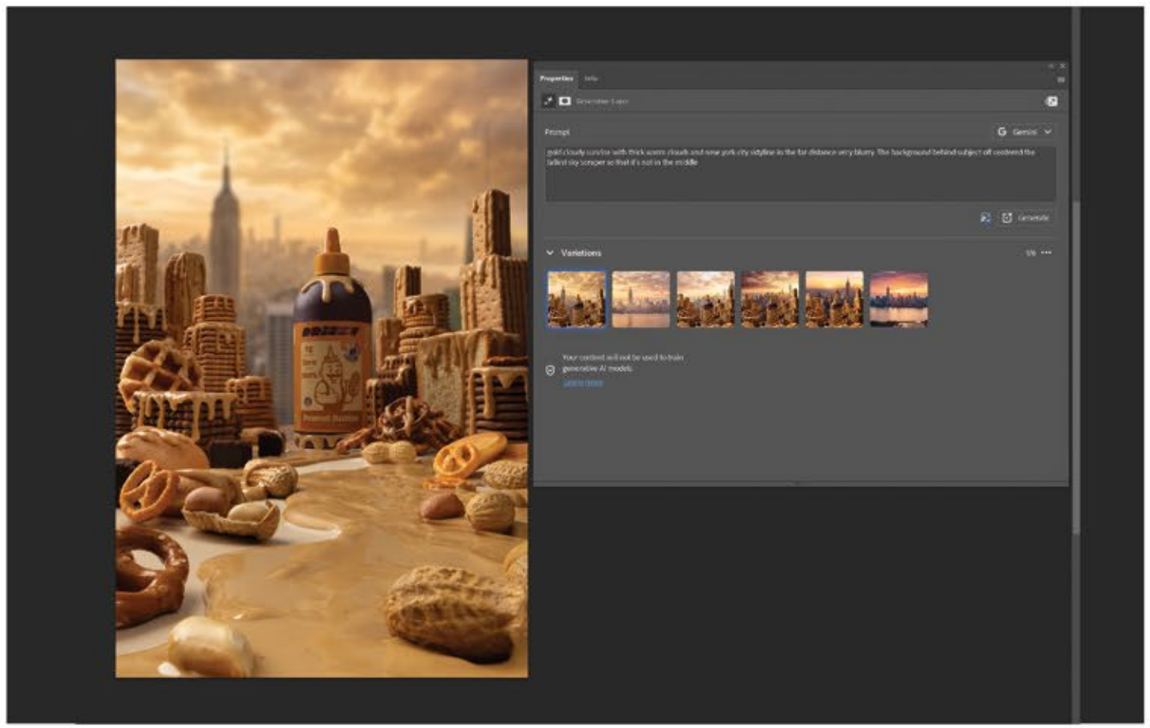
On my composite I added a lighter warm gradient on the left and a darker mustard brown gradient on the right overlapping both the background and my image. I also overlaid smog at a low opacity to both the AI background and the middle ground of the image.

Tips for Compositing – Selections are one of those small details that can make or break a composite. The edges of the object you're bringing in need to make sense with the edges of the objects around it. If you're dropping a piece into something with soft edges, use selection modifications like Feather and Smooth to match the softness of its environment.

Very few things in the real world have a razor sharp, pixel perfect edge. Feathering softens that transition and helps take the digital edge off.

- Go to Select > Modify > Feather (or press Shift + F6).
- Choose your pixel radius. A slight feather of 1 to 3 pixels can take the digital edge off a hard object. For deeper blending, increase it significantly, sometimes to 10+ pixels.







This is a checklist of things to consider when merging objects:

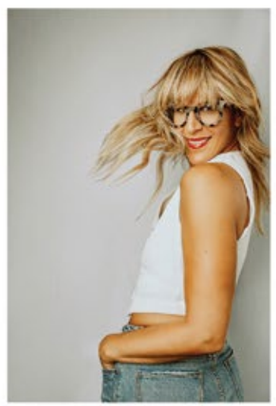
Edges
Color
Texture
Sharpness / Focus
Grain / Noise
Lighting
Contrast / Tonal Range
Perspective
Scale
Depth of Field
Shadows
Reflections / Interaction with the Environment

Once everything was in place, I made a few final adjustments to the overall picture, adding highlights and shadows with a Curves adjustment layer. Brightening the highlights and darkening the shadows gives the objects more drama. Then, I masked my adjustments so they made sense. We don't want sharpness and highpass filters applied to a blurry background. It gives an unrealistic HDR look.

Seven hours, a lot of peanut butter, plenty of mess, and 27 images later, I had my final image.

That little quote on my fridge turned out to be pretty good advice. Sometimes getting out of creative autopilot means taking on something that makes us wonder, "What exactly did I just agree to?" Then, figure it out one frame, one layer, and one problem at a time. Sometimes the best way to shake up your Groundhog Day is to bite off more than you can chew – and then, well… chewing.

Michelle VanTine is a commercial photographer specializing in consumer-packaged goods (CPG) and sports. She also works as a professional retoucher for national advertising campaigns including brands such as Coors Light, Miller High Life, and Pacifico. Her commercial client roster includes products found on shelves at ULTA Beauty, Sephora, Target, and Whole Foods Market. She works across sports and product photography and has photographed multiple Olympic and professional athletes. She served as Senior Staff Writer for Fstoppers, where she covered gear reviews and creative processes. Michelle will be teaching a class on "Advanced Commercial Retouching" at the 2027 Texas School of Professional Photography.



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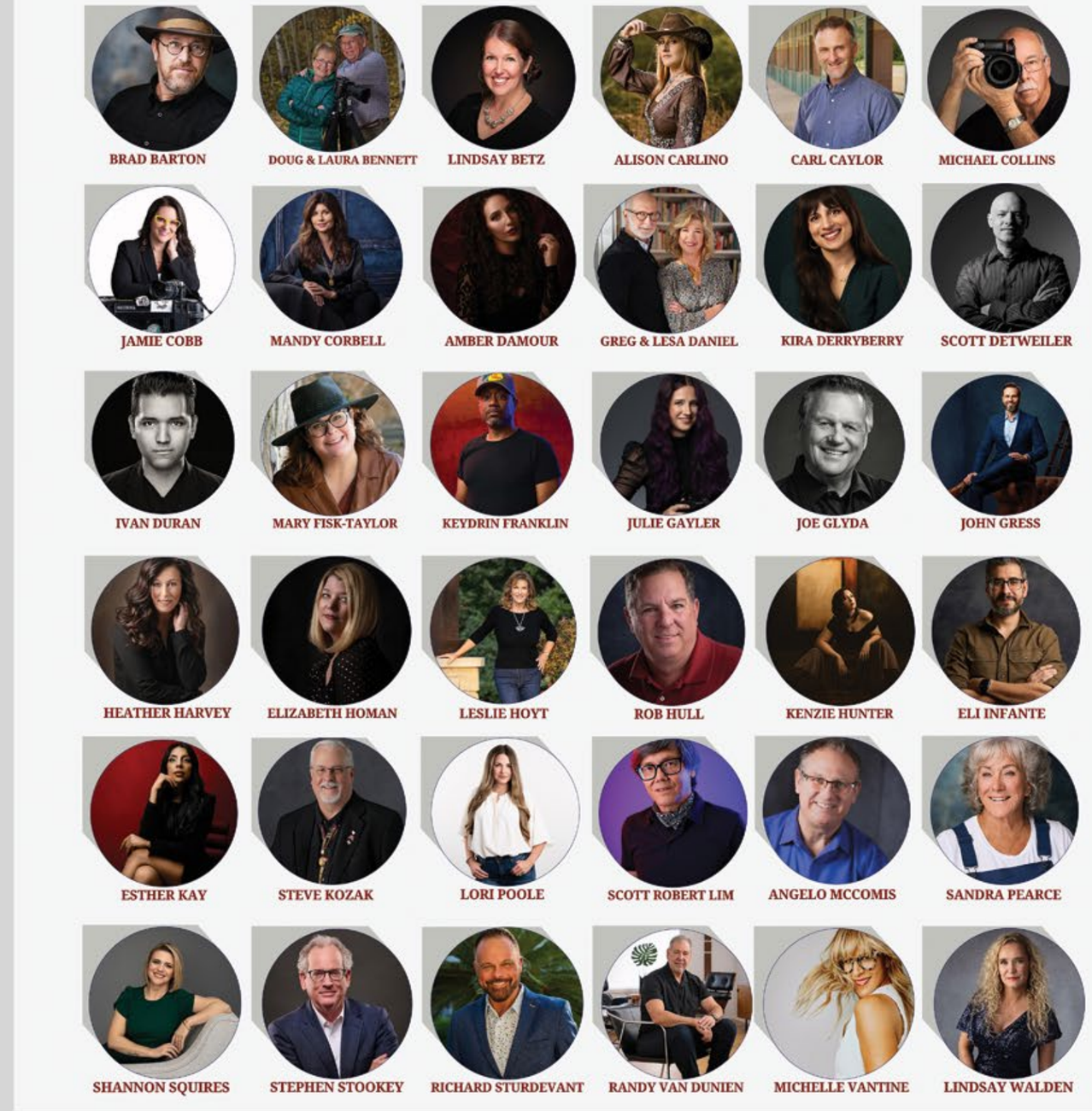
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CHASING THE STORY

Authentic Moments in the American West

by
Amy Peterson

Over Memorial Day weekend, seven of us loaded nine horses into two trailers and headed south to the Pahsimeroi Valley in Idaho for two full days of riding. We had been to the Pahsimeroi before, mostly for hunting, but we had never experienced it on horseback. Over the years I've taken my camera along on hunting trips to this area and entered a number of the images in competition, including one that became a Finalist in the Professional Photographers of America International Photographic Competition, earning a Bronze Medal.

For years I had thought about coming back with horses and seeing more of this country while I still can. Places like this feel increasingly special to me, and I never want to take for granted that we'll always have the same opportunity to experience them the way we do today. My objective was to photograph the western lifestyle and to scout the area as a possibility for a future Gentleman on Horseback ride. Mostly, this trip was for us... good friends, good horses, campfire meals, and miles of country to explore.

The Pahsimeroi Valley sits beneath the Lost River Range with Mt. Borah and Leatherman Peak rising in the distance. We were camped and riding at around 8,000 feet, surrounded by sagebrush, two-track roads, cattle trails and snow-covered peaks. It is the kind of place where, as a photographer, I want to photograph everything I see. But this wasn't a photo shoot. I was there to ride and enjoy the weekend with others. None of the photographs were staged. However, I was watching for those moments when the light, landscape, horses and people happened to come together.

Western life has always been part of who I am. I grew up in the mountains of North Idaho. Horses, hunting, ranch life and the outdoors aren't subjects I discovered because I became a photographer. They were part of my life long before I ever thought about photographing them. Maybe that's why I'm drawn less to making western life look a certain way and more to photographing how it actually feels.

Some great photographs are planned and then executed. I might scout a location, study the light, watch the weather, and even pack horses into the backcountry to camp so I can be there at the right time. Sometimes I might have an idea of the atmosphere and a story, but this trip was different. I was there to ride. I just happened to bring my camera along.

Our mornings started around dawn: feeding the horses, cooking breakfast over an open fire, and eating around 8 am. An hour later, we would have the horses saddled, lunches, and water packed into our saddlebags, and be ready to head out for the day.

We rode two-track roads into the foothills and then cross-country through sagebrush, often following trails made by cattle ranging in the area. The mountains were around us all the time, but getting close to those big peaks could take hours. We rode most of the day, usually choosing a lunch spot where we could give the horses and ourselves a break while taking in a beautiful view.

By the time we rode back into camp it was often getting dark. We'd unsaddle and take care of the horses, then settle in around the fire for a delicious camp meal and share stories from the day. When the fire burned down, there was that huge Idaho sky overhead, completely filled with stars. And yes, the photographer in me immediately sees another opportunity there too. Those wide-open, dark mountain skies can make some incredible nightscape photographs. There is always something else to photograph, and that's also where being a photographer and being part of the adventure can sometimes conflict.





After riding for hours, you might suddenly find yourself looking at an incredible mountain scene and thinking how amazing it would look in early morning light or at sunset. Unfortunately, it might be the middle of the day, and you can't always wait. It might take another two or three hours of riding to get safely back to camp; staying until sunset isn't necessarily an option. Horses, terrain, weather and daylight all matter more than the

photograph. So you make the best image you can with the conditions you're given, or you make a mental note and hope someday to return with a better plan.

I did a lot of that on this trip. I would look at a place and imagine packing in with a canvas tent, setting up beside a creek and spending enough time there to photograph the entire experience in beautiful light. I was quietly scouting photographs almost everywhere we went. There is always next time, and now I have knowledge I didn't have before. But there is also something to be said for making the photograph you have instead of being disappointed about the photograph you wish you had.

One morning before breakfast, I decided to bring my camera along while watering the horses. The early morning light was quite beautiful and I thought I might get a few photographs around camp. While we were out, Taylor came over ponying another horse. I photographed her from a distance and then, as she came closer, I asked her to make another circle. I was watching the sun coming over the mountains and really liked the backlight and side light I was getting. That was the photograph I thought I wanted.

Then, she rode behind me. I turned around and suddenly the early morning light illuminated her and the horses beautifully from the other direction. The colors popped, the mountains lined up behind her, and the stormy morning sky added another layer to the scene. I hadn't intended to photograph that direction at all. Over the years, I've learned to look behind me, especially when the light is changing. It sounds simple, but it is something I still have to consciously remind myself to do.

When we see a beautiful scene, we tend to lock onto it. We find our composition, find the light we want, and concentrate on making that photograph. Meanwhile, something entirely different may be happening behind us. Sometimes the photograph you planned simply puts you in position for the photograph you didn't plan.



The next morning gave us an even bigger reminder that plans can change quickly in the mountains. It had been a fairly normal morning. We had eaten breakfast and were just about ready to ride. Most of us were already mounted while a few people finished some groundwork with their horses and packed water and lunches into saddlebags. I looked to the west and the sky was black. It got ugly amazingly fast.

We could see lightning in the distance moving toward us. At first, we watched it, thinking it might pass. but it kept getting closer until the storm was right over us. Everyone got off their horses, pulled out rain slickers, and covered what gear and saddles we could. A few people took shelter in the back of one of the horse trailers while a couple of us stayed outside holding horses, turning our backs to the rain as much as possible.

We were soaked. It was exciting, a little spooky, and, looking back, pretty funny. Photographically, though, it was incredible. The storm coming across the mountains created the kind of scenery and light you couldn't order if you tried. During the worst of it I remember thinking about how amazing the photographs could be. But my camera was put away.

There was simply too much going on. We were dealing with horses, lightning, and pouring rain. Safety and the well-being of the horses came first. I grabbed a few cell phone pictures when I could, but that was one of those times when being a photographer had to take a back seat to being part of what was happening. There will always be that photograph you should have gotten that haunts you forever. But the journey is part of what I want to remember too. If I spend the entire time thinking about photographs, I can miss some of the experience I'm trying so hard to preserve.

I've also learned not to automatically be disappointed when conditions aren't what I hoped for. Some of my favorite photographs have come from situations that initially looked like complete failures. Several years ago I drove about eight hours south to photograph a branding.

I love photographing brandings and authentic ranch life, and I was really looking forward to it. Then it rained. Everyone was disappointed, but instead of giving up on photographs altogether, we grabbed our slickers, bundled up because the temperature had dropped, found a beautiful scenic area, and built a cowboy fire. The photographs we made out in that miserable weather are still some of my favorite images I've ever created.

I teach western lifestyle photography workshops in North Idaho and one of my favorite things happens at the end. I have everyone submit their top twenty photographs. After dinner and dessert, we watch a sideshow of everyone's images. Even if we had all been standing in essentially the same location, photographing the same horses, the same cowboys and cowgirls, the photographs are completely different. Someone sees the wide-open country. Someone else notices the detail in the tack or the markings on a horse. Another photographer catches a cowboy with a cigar, an interesting shadow, or a tiny interaction between two people. Some photograph through foreground elements. Others see natural lines that lead into the subject. Some take a very documentary or photojournalistic approach and tell the entire story through little moments. Inevitably someone says, "Why didn't I see that?"

I love that. That's photography. We can all stand in the same place with similar equipment and see something completely different. The more I photograph, the more I believe learning to see is every bit as important as learning the technical side of photography. Knowing your equipment matters because, when something happens unexpectedly, you need to be able to react without thinking through every camera setting. When I'm riding, I keep my gear simple for that reason. I use a Cotton Carrier harness that keeps my camera secure against my body but still accessible. I photograph both mounted and on the ground, depending on the horse I'm riding and whether it will stand quietly long enough for me to work.

For a day ride or overnight trip, I normally carry one camera body and one lens, usually my 70-200mm or 24-70mm. I bring two 128GB cards and two batteries. Extras go into my saddlebags, and I carry a wild rag that I can wrap around my camera if I decide it needs to be packed away. If we're working from a base camp where weight and accessibility aren't as much of an issue, I can bring more equipment, including my 200-800mm lens, which I love. But on horseback, lighter is better. The last thing I want is to be so consumed with equipment that I miss what's happening around me.

The Pahsimeroi trip wasn't a photo shoot. It was seven friends, nine horses, two full days riding in the mountains, and a chance to step away from everyday life for a little while. I came home with beautiful photographs, but I also came home with ideas for places where I want to return, photographs I still want to make, memories I didn't photograph at all and, yes, a few images I will probably always wish I had gotten. That's okay. There is always next time.

Although when Monday came and it was time to load the horses and start that twelve-hour trip home, I wasn't ready to leave. Honestly, I could have stayed there for months. There were more trails to ride, more country to explore, more locations I wanted to scout, and more photographs already forming in my mind. Maybe that's part of what keeps me wanting to go back.

I will continue to plan photographs, scout beautiful locations, and chase great light. But I will also keep reminding myself to turn around, look through things, pay attention to the little details, and be willing to change the plan when something better presents itself. Sometimes the best photographs aren't the ones we went looking for. They're the ones we were paying enough attention to see.

Amy Peterson is a North Idaho photographer specializing in western lifestyle, ranch, and portrait photography. A Master Photographer, Photographic Craftsman, and Certified Professional Photographer, Amy draws much of her inspiration from the mountains, horses, and western way of life that have surrounded her since childhood. She also teaches western lifestyle photography workshops, encouraging photographers to look beyond the obvious and find the story happening around them.





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THE ART OF SEEING

Letting Craft Lead You Into Creative Freedom

by
Leslie Hoyt
Texas School Instructor

When I first started using a camera, my goal was to record what I was seeing. I learned to expose correctly, select lenses intentionally, and make a photograph that described the subject clearly. Those skills matter. They are the foundation of everything that follows. But eventually, many of us begin to ask a different question: What if I photographed not only what I see, but how it feels to be there? That question marks the transition from looking to seeing.

Looking is the physical act of noticing what's in front of us. Seeing is more intentional. It requires us to slow down and become aware of the visual qualities that draw us in: a shifting shadow, reflected color, the rhythm of branches, weathered paint, or the quiet mood of a familiar place. It also asks us to notice our response to the scene before we make a literal record of it.

For me, this kind of seeing has become the beginning of more personal, abstract, and impressionistic photographs. My goal has become capturing the "essence" of a scene. It is a practice available to every photographer, regardless of subject matter or equipment. You do not have to abandon the technical expertise you've worked years to perfect to work more expressively. In fact, the discipline we develop through years of studying photographic craft can give us permission to let go.

Craft Becomes Instinct – I grew up photographically in the PPA image-competition world. I received merits, IEs, won trophies, got ribbons, medallions, a bunch of bronze, silver, gold, and diamond pins, and was on the stage for the GIAs a couple of times. That experience served me well. I had studied the Twelve Elements of a Merit Image and learned to consider impact, composition, color balance, and the other elements each time I clicked the shutter.

At first, those ideas felt like things to remember and evaluate. I consciously considered whether the composition led the eye where I intended, whether the lighting supported the subject, whether the colors worked together, and whether the image had visual impact. Over time, however, the principles became less like a checklist and more like a visual language. They became instinct.

That internalized foundation still guides me now, even when I am making photographs that are not intended to be literal. It helps me recognize when a scene has potential. It helps me decide whether an experimental multiple exposure is balanced or confusing, whether a color shift adds emotion or becomes distracting, and whether a blurred image feels expressive rather than simply out of focus.

Technical knowledge and artistic freedom are not opposites. The visual discipline you have practiced can become a quiet guide when you experiment. It is there in the background, helping you make choices without requiring you to control every outcome.

Begin With Your Response – When you find a subject, pause before deciding what image you're going to make with it. Instead, ask what first caught your attention. Was it color? Atmosphere? Repeating shape? Reflection? Dramatic contrast? The suggestion of movement? A feeling of mystery, tension, nostalgia, stillness, or joy?

The answer does not need to be logical. But that initial response can guide the photograph more effectively than a literal inventory of the scene.

Imagine standing near a row of trees on a windy afternoon. A straightforward photograph may document trunks, branches, and landscape. But perhaps what you really respond to is the movement: leaves flickering in sunlight, branches swaying, and the sense that the whole scene is alive.



Once you recognize that response, make photographic choices that support it. Use a slower shutter speed and move the camera vertically during the exposure. Make a multiple exposure that layers branches into a more complex rhythm. Adjust color later to emphasize the mood that first attracted you.

The final image may no longer be a literal record of the trees. But it may communicate the experience of standing among them more truthfully.

Slow Down and Look Closer – Expressive photographs often begin with ordinary subjects. The potential for abstraction is all around us, but it is easy to miss when we are searching only for grand landscapes or obviously beautiful subjects.



Look for the raw visual ingredients within a scene:

- Lines, curves, shapes, and negative space
- Repetition, rhythm, and patterns
- Reflective surfaces
- Interesting texture
- Motion, or the suggestion of motion
- Small fragments rather than the complete scene

Reflections in windows, puddles, or polished metal can offer visual possibility. Architecture can become studies in line, geometry, shadow, and repetition. Nature provides endless variations in texture, translucency, and movement. A decaying wall, peeling paint, a cluster of leaves, or a small area of reflected color can become compelling when you let yourself respond to it.



Work a subject longer than you think you should. Rather than making one photograph and moving on, circle around it. Move closer. Step back. Change your angle. Isolate a detail. Turn the camera vertically. Exclude the part that explains the scene. Watch how the light changes. Ask yourself, “What else is here?” Often, the most expressive image emerges only after the obvious photograph has been made.

Use the Camera Creatively – Once you notice the expressive possibilities in a scene, your camera can become more than a recording device. It can become an active partner in interpretation.

Intentional Camera Movement – Intentional camera movement, or ICM, translates the feeling of motion into a photograph. Rather than holding the camera still, you deliberately move it during a longer exposure. The direction, speed, and shape of movement affect the result.

A vertical movement can emphasize the height and rhythm of trees, grasses, or buildings. A horizontal sweep can suggest motion in water, a broad landscape, or layers of color. A small circular or curved movement may create a more painterly, energetic effect. You can even zoom during your exposure for an interesting effect.

Begin simply. In lower light, choose a shutter speed slow enough to allow movement – perhaps 1/15 second, 1/8 second, or longer – and make a smooth, deliberate motion during the exposure. In brighter conditions, use a neutral-density filter to reach slower shutter speeds without overexposing the image. The goal is not random blur. Let your movement relate to the subject and the feeling you want to express. Some attempts will not work; that is part of the process. The unexpected frame may reveal something you could not have planned.

Multiple Exposures – Multiple exposure (ME) photography offers another route beyond the literal view. Many camera bodies allow multiple exposures on the same frame. By combining two or more exposures in camera, you can layer forms, color, texture, and gesture. A stand of trees can become a rhythmic veil of repeated lines. A flower can become a soft, luminous abstraction. A simple scene can gain ambiguity and visual surprise.

Give each exposure a purpose. Make one frame for structure and another for movement. Combine a sharp subject with a blurred detail. Layer a close-up texture over a broader scene. Make rapid repeated images of the same scene with only the slightest movement to create an impressionistic image.

You do not need to predict the exact outcome. Trying to control every result can prevent discovery. Instead, work with awareness. Notice the color harmony, composition, and visual rhythm that make an image successful, while leaving room for chance.

Continue the Vision in Editing Editing is not merely a finishing step. It can continue the act of seeing. When you bring an image into Lightroom, Adobe Camera Raw, or Photoshop, return to your original response. What drew you to the subject? What mood did you hope to convey? What should remain clear, and what could be simplified, softened, layered, or transformed?

Cropping can strengthen an abstract composition by removing details that make the original scene obvious. Contrast can make a graphic image more assertive or allow a delicate image to remain quiet and atmospheric. Color can be simplified, muted, intensified, or harmonized to support the emotional tone.

Layer-based work in Photoshop can extend the possibilities of multiple exposure. You can combine photographs made at different times, blend a moving version of a scene with a still one, or experiment with opacity and blend modes. And layers are a great choice if your camera isn’t capable of multiple exposures.



The question is not, “How far can I push this file?” It is, “Does this decision help the image say what I want it to say?”

Recognize the Happy Accident – Serendipity is my new favorite word! Experimentation produces surprises. Some exposures will be unusable. Others will be technically imperfect but emotionally alive. The challenge is learning to distinguish an accident that is merely accidental from one that contains possibility.

Perhaps an ICM image has an unexpected streak of light across the frame. At first it may seem like a mistake. But if it creates a compelling line, reinforces the image’s energy, or leads the eye through the composition, it may be worth pursuing.

Perhaps a multiple exposure produces an unintended overlap of shapes. Before deleting it, look for visual rhythm. Does it create depth? Does it introduce a stronger center of interest? Does it suggest an emotion that a cleaner image does not?

Happy accidents are not simply luck. They are opportunities recognized by a trained eye. Make room for them by photographing generously and judging less quickly. When a frame feels intriguing but incomplete, ask what you might change in the next attempt: the movement, exposure, angle, color, number of frames, or balance between sharpness and blur.

Practice Seeing Differently – A more expressive approach does not reject representational photography or abandon excellence. It expands what photography can do. It moves us beyond documenting a subject and toward interpreting our relationship with it.

The next time you photograph, choose an ordinary subject you might normally overlook. Spend five minutes observing it before making an image. Identify one quality that attracts you: color, texture, light, shape, rhythm, reflection, or movement. Make a straightforward photograph first, then make at least ten interpretations by changing viewpoint, framing, focus, exposure, aperture, movement, or try multiple exposures. Later, ask which images communicate the feeling that first drew you in. The most meaningful image may not be the most predictable one. It may be the frame in which the subject begins to blur, light becomes more important than the object, or the familiar becomes something new.

Photography gives us a way to pause in a world that often moves too quickly. When we slow down, notice deeply, and trust the visual instincts we have developed, ordinary moments can become vessels for feeling. The camera becomes not only a tool for showing others what was there, but a way of revealing what it meant to us. That is the art of seeing.

Leslie Hoyt, M.Photog., Cr., is a lens-based mixed media artist whose work bridges photographic craft, creative vision, and fine-art processes. After a successful portrait-photography career, she transitioned to fine art and now exhibits in juried shows and galleries. Her practice begins with the camera and extends through digital post-processing and mixed-media techniques, transforming photographs into expressive works of art. Experience in image competition and service as a PPA juror gave Leslie a foundation in the visual elements needed for compelling imagery. These skills continue to guide her exploration of abstract photography and art. She will be teaching a class on “Track: Specialty and Technique” at the 2027 Texas School of Professional Photography.





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Ed Alexander
June 1941 – August 2026
Texas PPA President 1997 – 1998

TPPA Past President Passes

Celebrating the Life of Ed Alexander

by
Bill Hedrick

Ed Alexander was a devoted husband to his loving wife, Jo Beth Alexander, a devoted father and grandfather, and cherished his family and the many relationships he built during his lifetime. But one of the highlights of his life was serving as President of the Texas Professional Photographers Association in 1997–1998. Through his work and involvement, he made lasting contributions to the photography profession and to others who shared his passion.

Faith was an important part of Ed's life as well. He was a devoted and very active member of Concordia Lutheran Church, where he was involved for many years and faithfully served as an usher. His commitment to his church reflected his generous spirit and his desire to serve others.

Those of us who knew Ed will remember him for his steadfast commitment to his profession and this association. One of his achievements during his presidency was to double the circulation of the TPPA Magazine, sending extra copies to guilds and photographic vendors throughout the State of Texas. As a result, TPPA membership quickly increased and magazine advertising nearly doubled.

To this editor, he was more than a fellow TPPA member. He was a true friend. I will miss the times we shared and our conversations. He will truly be missed.





CINEMATIC MOTIVATED LIGHTING

For Boudoir Photography

by
Lori Poole
Texas School Instructor

Most traditional portrait lighting begins with a clear objective: illuminate the subject beautifully. We position the main light to shape the face, add fill to preserve detail in the shadows, and perhaps place another light behind the subject to create separation. It is a reliable approach to making a polished, flattering portrait. But boudoir asks the photographer to do more than flatter. In boudoir, we are rarely trying to reproduce ordinary reality exactly as it exists.

A boudoir client is not simply looking for an accurate record of what she looks like. She wants to see herself inside an experience – confident, sensual, powerful, mysterious, soft, glamorous, or perhaps unlike any version of herself she has seen before. A beautifully lit subject placed inside a room can accomplish some of that. But what might happen if the room itself became part of her transformation?

Build a Scene, Not a Lighting Pattern – The boudoir environment helps communicate fantasy, privacy, sensuality, softness, confidence, or power before the viewer consciously analyzes a single pose. How do we create a bedroom that feels a little more romantic, a dressing room that feels more glamorous, or a nighttime scene that feels more mysterious? The goal is not to make the light perfect. It is to make it purposeful.

What if the brightest light came from behind the subject? What if the shadows were allowed to remain shadows? What if, instead of lighting the woman and treating everything around her as background, we built the light for the world she was stepping into? We would probably break a few familiar lighting rules along the way.

We might also create something more immersive: photographs that feel less like poses arranged inside a photography set and more like moments unfolding within a story. The kind of images that make a client lean toward the screen at her reveal because she recognizes herself but has never seen herself quite like that.

This approach is often described as cinematic lighting, but the more useful term is motivated lighting. In filmmaking, motivated light behaves as though it comes from a believable source within the scene. That source may be visible, such as a lamp or a window, or it may simply be implied, like daylight entering through a window outside the frame. The light itself does not have to be natural. It has to be believable.

My process begins with a simple question: What is the light in this room supposed to be doing? Instead of building the light for one pose or camera angle, I build an environment in which the subject and I can move. I decide where the light appears to originate, what areas it should reach, and where it should fall away. Once that world has been established, I place my client inside it.

This is similar to the way a movie set is designed. The room is not simply a background behind an actor. The furniture, lamps, windows, color, shadows, and direction of the light work together to support the mood of the scene.

Decide Where the Light Belongs – Before reaching for a softbox, ask where light would come from if the room were real. It might enter through a window, glow from a bedside lamp, spill through a doorway, or come from the bulbs surrounding a vanity mirror. Choose one source to establish the room. Add layers only if needed.

In my studio, the strongest source is often a fabricated window placed in the background. It may be visible in the photograph, or it may sit just outside the composition. Although it is technically an artificial studio light, the viewer reads it as daylight entering the space.

This “window” frequently behaves more like a kicker or edge light than a conventional portrait key, yet it may be the most powerful source in the room. It can skim across a shoulder, trace the curve of a hip, separate hair from a dark background, or create a luminous highlight along the body while allowing the side nearest the camera to remain in shadow. Even when the viewer cannot see the source, the direction, color, and quality of the light should make sense within the imagined environment.

Let the Shadows Participate – Photographers are often trained to see shadows as problems to solve. We add fill to preserve detail, rotate the subject toward the key, or move the light until the face and body are evenly illuminated. In boudoir, shadow can do more than conceal. It can shape, simplify, separate, and suggest.

Depth does not come only from the places where light falls. It comes from the transition between what is illuminated and what is allowed to









recede. A bright outline along a shoulder feels more dimensional when the opposite side falls into darkness. A face emerging from shadow can feel private and intimate. A pool of light surrounded by a darker room directs attention with more subtlety than lighting every surface equally.



This does not mean losing control of the image. I still pay attention to where shadows cross the face and body, how much detail I want to retain, and whether the light supports the client's comfort and the intended mood. The difference is that I no longer assume every shadow requires fill. Sometimes the shadow is the point.

Expose for the Light Falling on the Subject – Once I set my exposure for a scene, I can often move through the scene with very few adjustments. I might photograph toward the light source, then turn toward a darker part of the room, then move to the subject's shadow side, and then shoot from the illuminated side. The composition and mood can change dramatically even though my exposure remains nearly the same.

Leaving my settings alone as I move through the scene feels counterintuitive because the camera's meter reacts to whatever fills the frame. When I include a bright window in the scene, the meter says I'm overexposed. When I turn away from the window and fill the frame with a dark wall, it says I'm underexposed. But what I need to pay attention to is not whether the meter reading has changed. It is whether the light falling on my subject changed.

If she remains in the same place and the intensity of the light on her remains consistent, my exposure for her does not suddenly need to change simply because I moved the camera. Moving my camera changed how the light appeared within the composition; it did not change the amount of light reaching my subject.

I can place a client in one lighting environment, expose her skin consistently, and create very different photographs by changing the angles between the source, the subject, and the camera. This is why I do not think of bright and airy or dark and moody as exposure settings. Underexposing a photograph does not automatically make it moody, just as overexposing one does not make it airy. Mood and exposure are not the same thing.

The exposure should change when the light on the subject changes. If she moves closer to the source, turns her body into or away from it, or steps into a different pool of light, I reassess. The important habit is to respond to what is happening on the subject rather than react automatically to the overall brightness of every new composition.

Allow Different Light Sources to Look Different – We are often taught to choose one color temperature and avoid allowing another to coexist within the same scene, keeping skin tones neutral and the light consistent. That can be useful when consistency is the goal. Atmosphere, however, often benefits from contrast. The difference helps us understand the sources instinctively. It can also create visual separation between the subject and the environment.

Rather than automatically avoiding those colors together, consider what each source contributes to the story. A cooler window can suggest morning, moonlight, or a crisp separation along the body. A warmer lamp can make part of the room feel inviting and intimate. When blended carefully, they can create dimension that brightness alone cannot provide.



When the Window Disappears – Recently, a client requested an entire session that looked as though it had been photographed at night. Much of my work relies on fabricated windows: large, diffused sources that imitate daylight entering the room. For this session, however, the usual window light would not work for the story we were trying to tell.

Removing the window forced me to stop relying on the lighting solution I knew and to think about how nighttime light would actually behave.

The answer was not simply to make everything darker. Darkness alone does not create night any more than underexposure creates mood.

If the scene were really happening at night, where would the light come from? I began building smaller, believable pools of illumination from warm lamps, candles, and directional spill that might plausibly come from an adjacent space. Anything beyond the reach of those sources was allowed to remain dark.

Without my usual window, I had to become more intentional about building the scene and layering the light. I realized that my approach was never truly about window light. It was about motivated light. Once the sources made sense for the world we were creating, the scene could still feel dimensional, intentional, and alive without my usual daylight.

Create a World Worth Entering – Boudoir gives us permission to get a little messy. The brightest light can come from behind the subject and shadows can remain shadows. Color temperatures do not have to match. A lamp can glow warmly in one corner while cool window light spills across the other side of the room.

Those choices are not careless simply because they depart from a traditional portrait-lighting formula. Each one can contribute to an environment that feels dimensional, believable, and emotionally charged. Boudoir is a genre built around transformation, and lighting the environment gives us another way to support that transformation.

When the light feels as though it belongs in the room, the set begins to feel like a place. When we allow highlights, shadows, color, and space to work together, the photograph begins to feel less constructed, even though every element may have been carefully designed. The client is no longer simply posing in front of a background. She is participating in a world created specifically for her.

That kind of work is satisfying for us as artists because it asks more of our imagination than repeating a familiar lighting recipe. It challenges us to decide what the photograph should feel like and then use our technical skills to create that feeling.

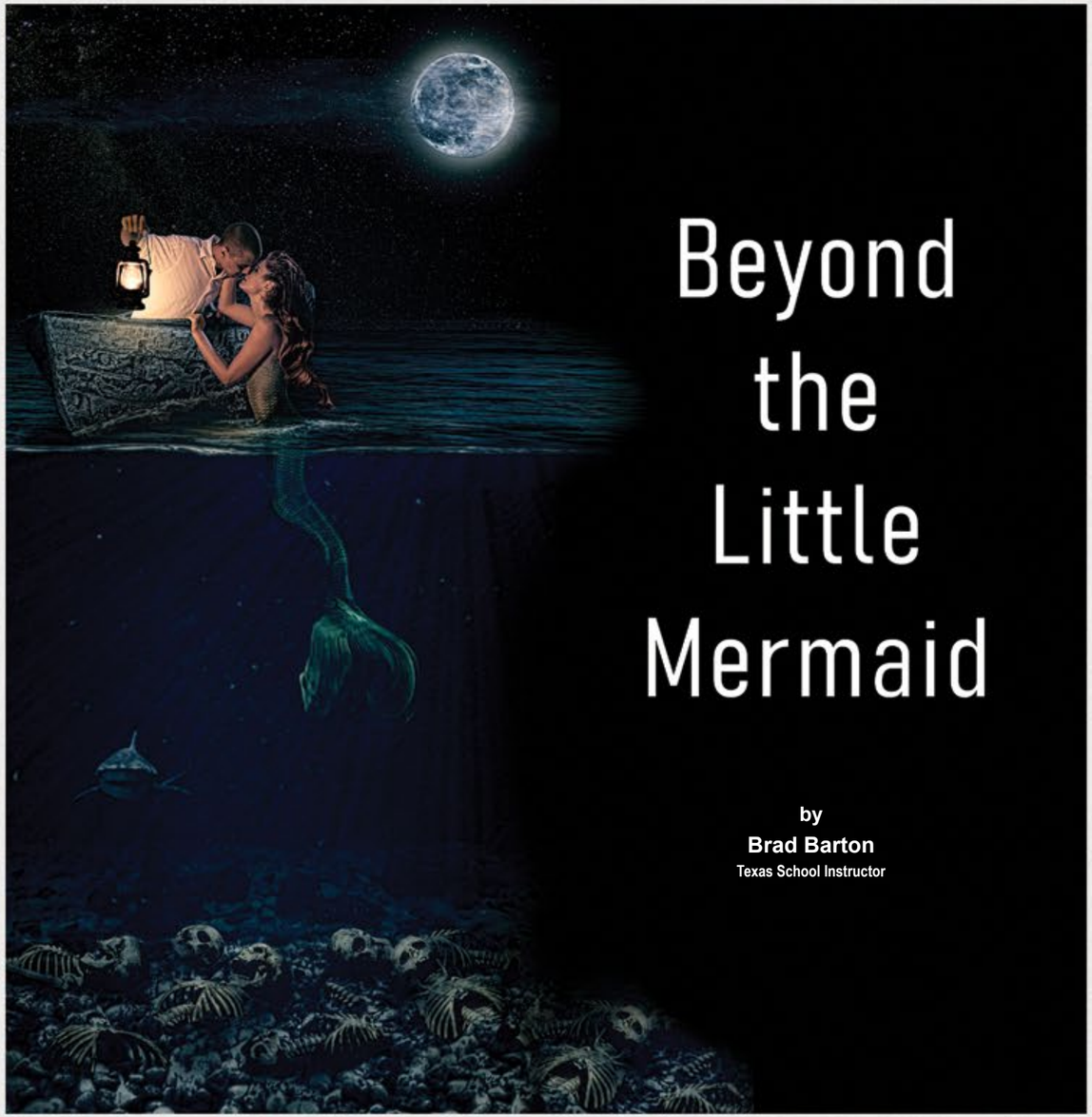
This matters to the client, too. She may not know the words motivated light, but she knows how the images make her feel. She sees herself inside a world that was created for her – one she could not have imagined, much less have made for herself.

Whether you are new to boudoir or have photographed it for years, give yourself permission to question the conventions you carried in from other genres. Let the strongest source come from behind your subject. Leave some shadows unfilled. Allow a warm lamp and cool window to occupy the same frame. Build the light for the room, establish your exposure, and then explore what happens when you and your subject move through it. Keep the rules that serve the photograph, and break the ones that do not.



Lori Unruh Poole is a full-time boudoir photographer and co-founder of Photo Insight, where she and her husband, Jeff, help photographers build profitable, sustainable businesses with clarity and confidence. Drawing on nearly two decades behind the camera and in the sales room, she brings an approachable, no-fluff, psychology-backed perspective to creativity, client experience, and business growth. Join Lori at Texas School for "The Modern Boudoir Studio."





Beyond the Little Mermaid

by
Brad Barton
Texas School Instructor

At first glance, it looks like a love story: a sailor leans over the side of a battered boat, lantern in hand. A beautiful mermaid rises from the moonlit water to meet him. Their faces are inches apart. He's completely captivated. He's also going to die. Look beneath the surface and the story changes. Her tail disappears into the darkness. A shark circles below. Scattered across the ocean floor are the skeletons of the sailors who apparently found her just as irresistible.

The image began with a simple premise: my client and I wanted to create a mermaid. But we wanted a mermaid of legend, not a mermaid singing about wanting legs. We wanted dangerous. We wanted a creature of myth, beautiful enough to lure sailors toward her and deadly enough that those sailors never made it home.

So, I started reading the legends and studying the old painters' representations and found the powerful, frightening mermaids of old. Mermaids aren't nice people. That one observation sold the client and gained her trust immediately. Posing her boyfriend leaning over the back of a chair while she knelt on the floor, stretching up toward him, wasn't questioned. The story had already sparked her imagination.

A visit to a pet store gave me images of fish tails and rocky ocean floor. A moonlit night, a stock boat and shark, and a Halloween skeleton completed the scene, and "Poor Unfortunate Souls" was born.

That first image didn't get mermaids out of my system. It did the opposite. Researching one story uncovered another, and making one image suggested questions I hadn't thought to ask before. What did mermaids look like before popular culture made them pretty? Were they always women? Were they even really mermaids, or had centuries of storytelling blended together sirens, sea spirits, and monsters from different traditions? One image had become a rabbit hole.

The temptation when we have a successful idea is to declare it finished. We made the image. We checked the box. Time to find another idea. But what if the first image isn't the end of the idea? What if it's only the first question? Sometimes the best thing you can do with an idea is follow it.

Mermaids are a fantastic subject because there isn't just one mermaid story. There are thousands of stories stretching back through history... some friendly, some indifferent, some downright evil. Following an idea doesn't mean repeating yourself. The mermaid images that followed were sometimes storytelling, sometimes abstract, sometimes portraits, but they all had that common thread tying them together.

Exploring those stories led to a profitable summer mermaid promotion as well as my first foray into underwater photography with a professional mermaid. It's funny how an idea can even lead to an entirely new skill set.

The instinct after making something successful is: What should I do next? The more productive question is: What else can I do with this idea?

An idea is rarely exhausted by our first interpretation of it. More often, we've simply found the most obvious interpretation first. So let's break this process into steps.

Research It – Where did the idea come from? What's its history? How have painters, writers, filmmakers, sculptors, musicians, etc. interpreted it? With mermaids, that opens mythology, folklore, sirens, sea monsters, sailors' stories, and classical art. Research isn't about finding an image to copy. It's about discovering questions you didn't know existed.

Change the Interpretation – If the first one was beautiful, make it frightening. If it was narrative, make it abstract. If it was elaborate, simplify it. If it was controlled, introduce chance.

Change the Problem – Take the camera underwater. Use a location you've never used. Work with a different kind of performer. Combine two disparate ideas and make something new. Suddenly the same subject requires new skills and creates different possibilities.

Follow the Tangent – Something discovered while researching mermaids might lead to Greek mythology, which leads somewhere else entirely. The tangent isn't always a distraction. Sometimes that's where the next body of work comes from. Follow the rabbit hole. You never know where it will lead.

Experiment – Does the idea require developing a new skill or trying a technique you've never done? Embrace the idea. Explore underwater photography. Learn compositing techniques in Photoshop. Use a different lens, a different aperture, or a different lighting pattern. Throw out your checklists of what makes a photograph, and do something you haven't done before. Amazing things rarely happen inside your comfort zone.

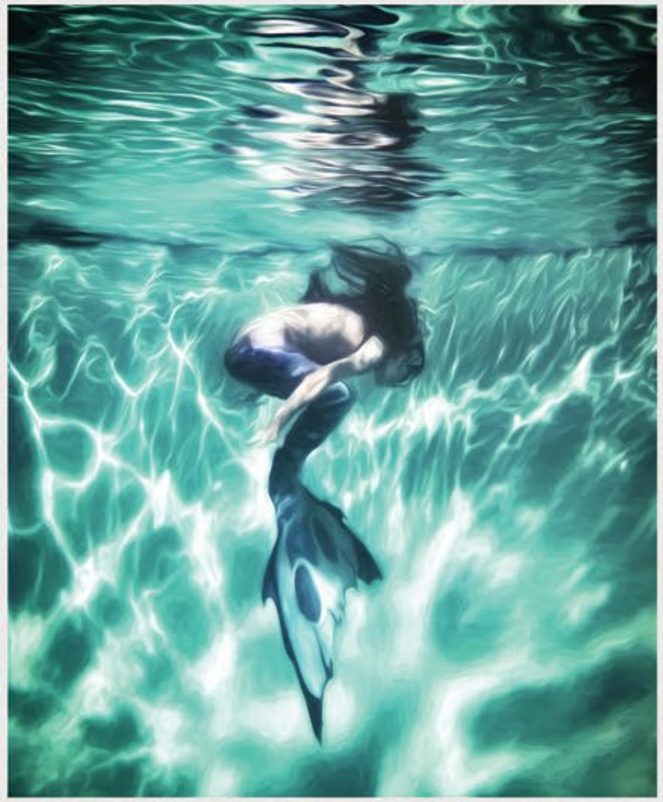
Through all that research and experimentation, give yourself a place to collect what you find. Keep a notebook. Your Creative Notebook is a safe space. There are no bad ideas there, just thoughts.

Write down the stupid ideas. Especially the stupid ideas. Save the reference that caught your attention. Write down the questions lacking answers. Sketch the composition badly. Make a note about the painting you saw at a museum, the line from a book, or the weird thing you noticed while waiting in traffic.

Don't worry about whether any of it is useful yet. That's not the notebook's job. It collects the ideas for those moments you feel directionless. Those are the moments the notebook becomes inspiration. Inspiration becomes story. Story is what turns a photograph into an image and turns a photographer into an artist. Photography isn't just about subjects. It's about stories.

That story doesn't have to involve a mermaid, an elaborate costume, a fully realized set, or hours in Photoshop. Sometimes the story is already happening in front of you. You just have to recognize it. I think this is why birds fascinate me.

I can't pose them. I can't tell them where to stand or ask them to turn their head toward the light. I certainly can't explain the concept and hope they'll buy into it. All I can do is watch. But birds are constantly telling stories.



They're fighting over territory, courting, raising families, stealing from one another, showing off, being ridiculous, being graceful, and occasionally appearing to make very questionable life choices. The challenge isn't creating the story. It's recognizing it when it happens. The photograph of a bird is easy. The story is harder.

Pelicans are especially good at making this leap for me. On land, they have a ridiculous waddle. On water, they paddle around like ducks. In the air, they are incredibly graceful, flying in organized squadrons, or hunting solo. And when they open that beak, they are terrifying. They used to be dinosaurs. They haven't forgotten.

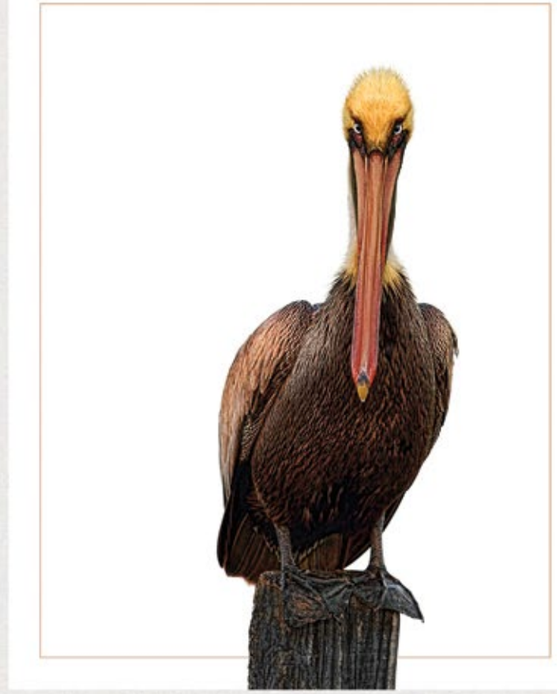
So one day, while photographing pelicans at a fishing dock, I watched the flock beg for scraps from the fishermen. One pelican stayed above the fray, perched upon a piling, slowly moving his head back and forth. Watching. Disapproving. It resulted in one of my most successful images: "Disapproving Pelican." That pelican was telling me a story, and I followed it.

Inspiration doesn't always announce itself. Creativity is recognizing it.

Sometimes inspiration starts with a client who wants to be a mermaid. Other times, it's buried in an old painting or a story written hundreds of years ago. It can be from an idea scribbled in a notebook that didn't make sense when you wrote it down. And sometimes it's a pelican sitting on a piling looking disappointed in everyone around him.

The important part is what happens next. Be curious. Ask questions. Do the research. Try something you're not quite sure you know how to do. Follow the tangent when it leads somewhere interesting.

And don't be too quick to declare an idea finished simply because you've made one successful image. Your first idea may be the obvious one. Your second might be better. Your tenth might be ridiculous. Write that one down.





Creativity is a tool, not a talent. It can be honed, practiced, strengthened. So find those mermaids, follow that rabbit hole, chase your Beautiful Monsters. There's a story waiting over there. Follow it.

Brad Barton, M.Photog.M.Artist, CPP, is a photographer, artist, author, educator, and creator of Creative Mythologist. He has spent more than two decades helping photographers develop both technical skills and creative vision. His work has earned recognition in photographic competition, been exhibited internationally, and appeared in books, galleries, and publications. As an author and educator, Brad is passionate about helping photographers create images that are more meaningful, distinctive, and personal. Brad believes creativity is not a talent reserved for a fortunate few, but a skill that can be developed through curiosity, practice, and intentional effort.



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